THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER SEVEN

“IF SHE BE WORTHY”

July 18 – November 24, 2008
New York • San Diego • London • Los Angeles • Chicago

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

FADE IN:

INT. AMC LOEWS LINCOLN SQUARE - IMAX - NEW YORK CITY - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 18, 2008 - 12:01 A.M. EDT

The midnight IMAX premiere of THE DARK KNIGHT. A packed, hushed audience. On the giant screen, Heath Ledger's Joker sets a pile of money on fire. The audience is spellbound, and also sad: Ledger died in January, at 28.

In the back row: KEVIN FEIGE (35) and JON FAVREAU (41), in town for meetings, wearing baseball caps.

INT. AMC LOEWS LINCOLN SQUARE - LOBBY - LATER

SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 18, 2008 - 2:40 A.M. EDT

The crowd pours out, stunned. Feige and Favreau stand by an escalator, quiet.

FAVREAU
Well. The bar just moved.

FEIGE
It's a masterpiece. And it's grounded. No flying. No gods. No gamma. Everybody's going to say that's the future. Superheroes have to be "realistic."

FAVREAU
And next year we're going to tell the world there's a Norse god with a magic hammer who flies through space.

FEIGE
(smiling, despite himself)
We're going to tell the world the comics are the future. Nolan made Batman real. We're going to make Thor TRUE. Those aren't the same thing.

FAVREAU
You're gonna show the hammer at Comic-Con?

FEIGE
I'm going to show them the inscription.

FAVREAU
(slowly)
...All of it?

FEIGE
All of it.

CUT TO:

BOX OFFICE MOJO - MONDAY, JULY 21, 2008

'THE DARK KNIGHT' SHATTERS OPENING RECORD WITH $158.4 MILLION

Warner Bros. and DC's sequel tops "Spider-Man 3" for the biggest debut of all time. Marvel's "Iron Man" stands at $314 million domestic.

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS - FEIGE'S OFFICE - BEVERLY HILLS - DAY

SUPER: TUESDAY, JULY 22, 2008 - 4:00 P.M. PDT

The office has changed since 2006. The IRON MAN one-sheet is framed beside a FURY concept painting. On the desk sits a hard-shell case the size of a briefcase. LENORA HAYES (43) stands over it with her arms crossed. Feige opens it.

Inside, on black foam: MJOLNIR. A real, forged, weighted hammer. Gray Uru metal, a leather-wrapped handle, and runes etched into its sides. On the top face, in a circular band, is an engraved inscription.

LENORA
(reading aloud)
"Whosoever holds this hammer, if SHE be worthy, shall possess the power of Thor."

(looking up)
Kevin. That's not what it says in the comics.

FEIGE
It's what it says in our universe.

LENORA
You promised the world, in writing, that every film would be faithful to the source material. And now you're going to stand in front of six thousand people and change the most famous sentence in Marvel history.

FEIGE
I'm going to keep every story. Lee and Kirby. Simonson. Odin, Asgard, Loki, the Bifrost, Surtur, the Warriors Three, the Destroyer. The god of thunder. Full power. Planets moving. All of it, exactly.

(beat)
Thor in our universe is a daughter of Odin. She has always been. Not a gimmick. Not a replacement. Not a legacy. The first and only Thor.

LENORA
And when the boards light up and call it a betrayal?

FEIGE
Then we let the movie answer. Like we did with Tony.

(picking up the hammer with both hands; it's heavy)
Lenora, the whole mythology of Thor is one question. Are you worthy? Not "are you a man." Are you worthy. That's the story. That's always been the story.

LENORA
(a long breath, the lawyer giving way)
...My daughter's nine. She's going to lose her mind.

CUT TO:

EXT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - HALL H LINE - DAWN

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 26, 2008 - 5:30 A.M. PDT

The line again, longer than last year. The SUPERHERO HYPE CREW, now a tradition: GARY (42) in a War Machine shirt, PRIYA (23) in a full homemade Wasp costume, DARNELL (30) with his Gatorade cooler, and TOMMY (20) with a new goatee he is very proud of.

TOMMY
Thor today. Has to be. Marvel announced Thor for 2010. They haven't said a director, a cast, nothing.

DARNELL
I hear Branagh. Kenneth Branagh. The Shakespeare guy.

GARY
A Shakespearean actor directing a movie with a guy in a winged helmet throwing a hammer? Perfect. Thor's basically King Lear with lightning.

PRIYA
Thor in the comics is LITERALLY written in Shakespearean English. "Verily," "forsooth." Stan wrote it that way on purpose.

GARY
And whoever they cast, he better be huge. Thor's gotta look like he can lift a building.

Priya looks at him sideways. She doesn't say anything. She's been reading the rumor threads.

CUT TO:

INT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - HALL H - DAY

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 26, 2008 - 1:00 P.M. PDT

Six thousand five hundred people. The Marvel Studios logo blazes on the screens. The roar when the lights dim is louder than last year's. Feige jogs onstage to a standing ovation.

FEIGE
Last year I stood here and asked you to trust us.

Huge cheers.

FEIGE (CONT'D)
Iron Man. Three hundred and fourteen million dollars domestic. The Incredible Hulk. The biggest Hulk opening ever. Two movies. Two promises kept.

Chanting: "NO-BO-DY! NO-BO-DY!"

FEIGE (CONT'D)
So today, I want to ask you to trust us one more time. But first, some old friends.

JON FAVREAU, MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (26) and TAYIA BOYD (26) walk out. The roar is deafening. Marc-Anthony is carrying a small cardboard sign that reads "HI MOM."

FAVREAU
We're making IRON MAN 2!

Pandemonium.

FAVREAU (CONT'D)
Comes out May 7, 2010. And I'll tell you one thing about it: the Iron Man suit Tony's wearing at the end of the first movie? It's not the last one.

MARC-ANTHONY
(leaning into his mic)
Also, the movie is a Broadway musical now. I have nine songs. Tayia has a power ballad about the filing system at Stark Industries.

TAYIA
(dead serious)
It's called "Alphabetical." It's very moving.

Laughter roars through the hall. A FAN in an Iron Man helmet yells from the floor:

FAN
WHERE'S WAR MACHINE?

Marc-Anthony and Favreau exchange a look. Just for half a second, something passes between them. Then Marc-Anthony smiles.

MARC-ANTHONY
Rhodey always comes. That's all I can say.

Gary, in the front row in his War Machine shirt, pumps his fist.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - STAGE - LATER

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 26, 2008 - 1:38 P.M. PDT

The Iron Man team has taken their seats. Feige walks to the center of the stage alone. The lights dim to near black. A low rumble of thunder rolls through the speakers.

FEIGE
In 1962, Stan Lee and Jack Kirby introduced a god.

The giant screens fill with JOURNEY INTO MYSTERY #83: Thor, hammer raised, lightning crackling.

FEIGE (CONT'D)
A god who had to learn to be worthy. Coming to theaters... a little later than we told you. But coming. And today, I brought something from Asgard.

A hydraulic platform rises slowly from the stage floor in a column of white light and fog. On it, resting on a black stone pedestal: MJOLNIR. Real. Forged. Gleaming.

Six thousand five hundred people go completely silent.

A camera pushes in on the hammer's top face, projected forty feet tall on every screen. The engraved inscription fills the hall, letter by letter.

"WHOSOEVER HOLDS THIS HAMMER, IF SHE BE WORTHY, SHALL POSSESS THE POWER OF THOR."

Silence. Three full seconds.

Then a sound that is half gasp and half roar ripples through the hall. People turn to each other. Some are screaming. Some are booing. Most are just saying the same thing over and over: "SHE? SHE?"

In the front row, Priya has both hands over her mouth, tears already streaming. Gary is staring at the screen, mouth open. Darnell slowly sets down his Gatorade. Tommy keeps reading it over and over.

TOMMY
She. It says she. Does that mean... is Thor a...

PRIYA
(barely a whisper, eyes shining)
It means Thor's a woman.

On stage, Feige lets the noise wash over him. He doesn't flinch. When it settles slightly, he speaks.

FEIGE
I'll take questions in a moment. But before anyone asks me anything: every story Stan and Jack told about Thor, every story Walt Simonson told, they're all going to be on that screen. Asgard. Odin. Loki. The Destroyer. A god of thunder at full power. Nothing watered down.

(beat)
In our universe, Odin's firstborn has always been his daughter. That's who picks up this hammer. That's the only change. And I promise you, she is worthy.

A wave of applause, thunderous and loud, though not universal. A few boos persist in the back. Feige gestures at the hammer.

FEIGE (CONT'D)
Anybody want to try?

Marc-Anthony immediately jumps up from his chair, jogs over, wraps both hands around the handle, braces, and HEAVES. The hammer, bolted to the pedestal as a gag, doesn't budge. He strains theatrically. His face turns red. He collapses onto the stage floor, panting.

MARC-ANTHONY
(into his headset mic, from the floor)
It says "she," Kevin! I never had a chance! This is discrimination!

The hall explodes with laughter. Even some of the booers crack up. Tayia walks over, pretends to try, and pretends to nearly lift it before Feige "stops" her. Bigger cheers.

TAYIA
I almost had it.

FEIGE
You're Pepper Potts. You're worthy of a lot of things. Just not that.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - Q AND A - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 26, 2008 - 1:52 P.M. PDT

At the audience mic, a heavyset MAN (30s) in a Thor helmet with a plastic winged crest. Arms folded.

THOR HELMET FAN
Kevin. Two years ago you put it in writing. "Faithful to the source material." Thor is a man. For forty-six years. How is this faithful?

A ripple through the crowd: some cheers, some groans. Feige nods, taking it seriously.

FEIGE
That's a fair question, and I'm not going to dodge it. Here's my answer. In the comics, Mjolnir has been lifted by Beta Ray Bill, a horse-faced alien. By Captain America. By Eric Masterson, a mortal architect. The point of Thor has never been who Thor is on the outside. The point is worthiness.

(beat)
Every word of every Thor story will be honored. The only thing different is who the hammer chose. And I'd ask you to do what you all did for Tony and for Bruce. Wait for the movie. Judge her then.

THOR HELMET FAN
(a long beat, reluctant)
...Fine. But if she can't move a planet, I'm writing a very long post.

FEIGE
If she can't move a planet, I'll write it for you.

Laughter and applause. The helmet fan walks away, still frowning, but nodding. Next at the mic: Priya. In her full Wasp costume. Shaking.

PRIYA
Hi, Kevin. It's me again.

FEIGE
(laughing, recognizing her)
The Avengers #1 girl!

PRIYA
I just want to say thank you. I'm an engineering student. Last year I was one of four girls in my thermodynamics class. And I've read Thor my whole life and never once thought I could be her. That's all. Thank you.

She steps back. The applause swells, real and growing. The hall is moved. Feige has to clear his throat.

FEIGE
(quietly)
Thank you, Priya. That's exactly why.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - SIMONE'S BEDROOM - VIEW PARK - CONTINUOUS

G4's ATTACK OF THE SHOW is on the small TV on Simone's dresser. The inscription is frozen on screen: "IF SHE BE WORTHY." SIMONE (28) lies on her bed eating grapes. ESTHER SMILLEY (25) sits on the floor at the foot of the bed, completely motionless, staring at the screen.

SIMONE
Well. That's new.

Esther doesn't answer. She watches Priya's speech on the screen. Her eyes are wet.

SIMONE (CONT'D)
(gently)
Esther.

ESTHER
(still staring)
A warrior. A god. A grown woman who leads armies and carries a hammer that only the worthy can lift.

(beat)
I play a nun who sings to a goat.

SIMONE
You want it.

ESTHER
(very quietly, almost afraid to say it)
I want it so badly I can't breathe.

A beat. Simone sits up and looks at her baby sister seriously.

SIMONE
Then you're going to have to want it louder than Daddy says no.

The door swings open. CELESTE SMILLEY (48) stands there with a stack of folded laundry. She glances at the TV. The inscription. Then at Esther's face.

CELESTE
What on earth are you two watching?

SIMONE
(instantly)
G4. I'm dating a gamer. Don't ask.

Celeste rolls her eyes, sets down the laundry and leaves. Esther hasn't moved. She's still looking at the hammer.

CUT TO:

MONTAGE - THE INTERNET DIVIDES

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 26 TO SUNDAY, JULY 27, 2008

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "'IF SHE BE WORTHY' - THOR IS A WOMAN??? DISCUSS" (Page 1 of 612)

NoNerfsPlz (Jul 26, 2:20 PM)
I'm the girl who asked the question. I'm still shaking. THOR IS A WOMAN. FULL POWER. MOVES PLANETS. I have never been this happy in my life.

ShellHead1963 (Jul 26, 2:31 PM)
I'll be honest. My first reaction was "they broke the promise." Then I remembered I said the same thing about the Kid Mayor. 206 apologies later, I'm reserving judgment.

Mjolnir_Worthy (Jul 26, 2:35 PM)
My username is literally Mjolnir_Worthy and I've never been more conflicted. Faithful means FAITHFUL. You can't just change the main character.

WarMachineRox (Jul 26, 2:40 PM)
Feige's answer about Beta Ray Bill was a mic drop. Thor's essence is worthiness, not gender. A horse alien lifted it in 1983 and nobody rioted.

ThorOdinson4Ever (Jul 26, 2:58 PM)
THIS IS POLITICAL CORRECTNESS. Marvel caved. Boycott.

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Jul 26, 3:05 PM)
Bro said the same thing about Tony and the Hulk. Both movies were 90%+ on Rotten Tomatoes. Marvel is 2-for-2. Let them cook.

Repulsor_Ray (Jul 26, 3:22 PM)
Real question: WHO? Who can play a god who can move planets?? That's the hardest casting in Marvel history.

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Jul 26, 3:25 PM)
Has to be a giant star. An action star. Someone who can lift a car.

NoNerfsPlz (Jul 26, 3:31 PM)
Or someone nobody expects. They keep doing that. Tony was the Kid Mayor. Banner was the slime kid. Watch, it'll be someone we'd never guess.

AIN'T IT COOL NEWS - JULY 26, 2008

MARVEL DROPS THE HAMMER: THOR IS A DAUGHTER OF ODIN, AND HALL H WILL NEVER BE THE SAME

Love it or hate it, Kevin Feige just made the boldest move of any comic book studio ever. The question is no longer "can they?" It's "who?"

FACEBOOK - GROUP: "SHE IS WORTHY (MARVEL'S THOR)" - Created July 26, 2008 - 147,019 members

Wall post - Jasmine T. (Howard University, '08): Little girls are going to grow up thinking the god of thunder looks like them. That's it. That's the post.

FACEBOOK - GROUP: "BOYCOTT FEMALE THOR - KEEP MARVEL FAITHFUL" - Created July 26, 2008 - 52,844 members

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

hallhpriya: i told kevin feige i never thought i could be thor and he said "that's exactly why." i will be okay eventually. probably. 3:40 PM Jul 26th from txt

marcanthonyb: tried to lift mjolnir at comic con. unworthy. going home to think about my life 6:12 PM Jul 26th from web

amondbaker: i wasnt at comic con this year because they dont trust me near microphones. but whoever she is: welcome to the team, your majesty 6:45 PM Jul 26th from web

CUT TO:

EXT. SHAKESPEARE'S GLOBE - BANKSIDE, LONDON - DAY

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 13, 2008 - 11:00 A.M. BST

The reconstructed Elizabethan theater on the south bank of the Thames. The open-air yard is empty. In the center of the bare stage stands KENNETH BRANAGH (47), the greatest Shakespearean director of his generation, holding a copy of JOURNEY INTO MYSTERY #83 like it's a First Folio. Feige stands in the yard below him like a groundling.

BRANAGH
(projecting, as if to an audience)
"Uneasy lies the head that wears a crown." Henry the Fourth, Part Two. That is your film, Kevin.

FEIGE
Tell me why.

BRANAGH
A king's firstborn. Proud. Gifted. Arrogant. Not yet ready to rule. Banished by her father to learn humility among mortals. Hal in the taverns of Eastcheap. And beside her, a brother who smiles while he plots. Loki is Iago, Kevin. And Edmund in LEAR. The bastard son who wants the throne.

FEIGE
And the daughter?

BRANAGH
(climbing down from the stage, intense now)
Lear had three daughters and never saw which one truly loved him. Odin has one daughter and must decide if she is worthy to inherit everything. That is not a gimmick. That is the oldest story in the theater. A child proving herself to a parent who cannot see her clearly.

Feige is quiet for a moment.

FEIGE
We build Asgard practically. Real sets. Real locations: Norway, Iceland. Real armor. She does her own fighting. Full power, every scene.

BRANAGH
I've been building castles out of plywood since 1989, Kevin. Let me build one out of stone.

(beat, a twinkle)
And when you cast her, find me someone who can make the verse sing. Someone who's been told her whole life to be a good girl and is secretly a warrior.

Feige doesn't know it, but somewhere in View Park, that woman is watching the hammer on a TV in her sister's bedroom.

CUT TO:

VARIETY - TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 2, 2008

BRANAGH TO WIELD HAMMER ON MARVEL'S 'THOR'

Shakespearean auteur will direct the Norse god epic for Paramount release; Marvel confirms the film's lead will be a daughter of Odin. Casting search begins "immediately," with locations scouted in Norway and Iceland.

CUT TO:

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS - LENORA'S OFFICE - BEVERLY HILLS - NIGHT

SUPER: SUNDAY, SEPTEMBER 14, 2008 - 8:20 P.M. PDT

Lenora is alone in the office on a Sunday night, in sweats, on her landline with a ghost-white face. CNN plays on a small TV: "BREAKING: BANK OF AMERICA TO BUY MERRILL LYNCH FOR $50 BILLION. LEHMAN BROTHERS PREPARES BANKRUPTCY FILING."

Feige bursts through the door, still in a T-shirt from a Sunday barbecue.

FEIGE
Tell me.

LENORA
Merrill Lynch doesn't exist anymore. As of tonight, Bank of America owns our credit facility. Five hundred and twenty-five million dollars. Captain America. Thor. The Avengers. All of it is now collateral at a bank that didn't make the deal and has never heard of us.

FEIGE
Can they call it?

LENORA
Not if we meet the covenants. Iron Man made sure we meet the covenants. But Kevin, there's no new money anywhere. Not for anybody. Every bank in America is going to freeze tomorrow morning. Lehman is filing at dawn. Wall Street is about to have the worst day since 1929.

Feige sinks into a chair. On the TV, footage of Lehman employees carrying boxes out of a building in Midtown Manhattan.

FEIGE
We have Iron Man 2 shooting in April. Thor in pre-production. Cap being written.

LENORA
We have the money for Iron Man 2. We have the money for Thor's development. We don't have the money to do everything at once. Not anymore. Something is going to have to give.

Her phone rings. She checks the caller ID: PATRICK DOYLE - MERRILL MEDIA FINANCE.

LENORA (CONT'D)
(answering)
Patrick. I've been expecting you.

PATRICK DOYLE (V.O.)
(exhausted)
Lenora. I want you to hear it from me before the press does. Bank of America has assured us the media portfolio will be honored. Your deal is the best-performing deal on our books. Iron Man is the only good news anybody at Merrill has had all year.

LENORA
And you, Patrick?

PATRICK DOYLE (V.O.)
(a bitter laugh)
Me? I'll find out on Tuesday. Good luck, Lenora. Tell Captain America I'm sorry.

CUT TO:

INT. DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT - EXECUTIVE WAR ROOM - BURBANK - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 15, 2008 - 1:05 P.M. PDT (MARKETS CLOSED)

A glass-walled boardroom high above the Donohue lot. A dozen screens: CNBC, Bloomberg, the NYSE ticker. The Dow is down 504 points. DNE, Donohue's stock, is down 6.8%.

NATASHA BULLOCK (47) stands at the head of the table in a black suit, cool as glass, while twelve executives in shirtsleeves look like they're drowning.

CFO (50s)
We lost ninety billion dollars in market value today. Theme park bookings for Q4 are already softening. Advertising is going to collapse. Consumer products...

NATASHA
Stop. We are not going to lose our minds in this room. We have no meaningful debt. We have the largest cash reserves of any company on Earth. Everyone else is drowning. We are going to be the lifeboat.

The door opens. VICTOR DONOHUE (72) walks in, cane in hand, impeccable. The executives instantly straighten.

VICTOR
Sit down, sit down. I've seen 1973. I've seen 1987. I watched the Dow lose twenty-two percent in one day, and I bought ABC stock that afternoon.

(to Natasha)
What's the plan, Tasha?

NATASHA
(clicking a remote)
Hold every employee. No layoffs at the parks. Keep the cruise ships sailing. And acquire.

A screen lights up with a stock chart. MVL, Marvel Entertainment, down sharply in the panic.

NATASHA (CONT'D)
Marvel Entertainment. Five thousand characters. Two of the most profitable films of the year. A studio that just proved it can build a universe. Their stock is getting dragged down with everything else. When this panic settles, I want to make them an offer.

Silence. The executives look from Natasha to Victor. Victor stares at the screen for a long time.

VICTOR
Your son works there.

NATASHA
Yes.

VICTOR
Your daughter works there.

NATASHA
Yes.

VICTOR
Tasha. If you buy that company, every newspaper in America will say the Donohues bought their children a universe.

NATASHA
(very calm)
Daddy, the children built that universe on their own. In front of everybody. Without us. That's exactly why it's worth buying. Nobody can ever say we gave it to them. They'll have to say they gave it to us.

Victor studies his daughter. A slow, approving smile spreads across his face.

VICTOR
You're more ruthless than I was.

NATASHA
I learned from the best.

VICTOR
Don't tell your son. Not yet.

NATASHA
Not for a year.

CUT TO:

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS - CONFERENCE ROOM - BEVERLY HILLS - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2008 - 3:30 P.M. PDT

A CNBC alert on the wall TV: "DOW PLUNGES 777 POINTS - LARGEST POINT DROP IN HISTORY - HOUSE REJECTS BAILOUT." Around the table: Feige, Lenora, Favreau, and MARC-ANTHONY, who came uninvited and isn't leaving.

A spreadsheet is projected on the wall: "IRON MAN 2 - REVISED BUDGET." One line is highlighted in red: "RHODES - TERRENCE HOWARD - REVISED OFFER."

LENORA
Bank of America sent new covenants on Friday. Every film over budget triggers a review. We're cutting everywhere. Visual effects, locations, marketing. And Terrence's deal.

MARC-ANTHONY
How much?

LENORA
(reluctantly)
His agents say the revised offer is a fraction of his first contract. They're calling it an insult. They're probably right.

FAVREAU
(quietly)
He was the first actor who signed on, Marc. When nobody believed in this, he was in.

MARC-ANTHONY
Then pay him. Take it out of mine. I'll do Iron Man 2 for free. Take my back end, all of it, and give it to Terrence.

LENORA
Marc, I can't do that.

MARC-ANTHONY
Why not?

LENORA
Because the bank won't let us move money between talent deals without a full renegotiation. Because Terrence's agents would have to agree. Because if we pay one actor out of another actor's pocket, every agent in town will expect the same thing on every movie we ever make. And because, honey, Terrence Howard is a proud man. Do you really think he'd accept charity from his co-star?

Marc-Anthony opens his mouth to argue. Then he closes it. He knows she's right about the last part.

MARC-ANTHONY
Let me call him.

FEIGE
Marc...

MARC-ANTHONY
I'm not asking permission, Kevin. He's my friend. Let me call him.

CUT TO:

EXT. TERRENCE HOWARD'S HOUSE - BACK PORCH - HOLLYWOOD HILLS - SUNSET

SUPER: MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2008 - 7:15 P.M. PDT

TERRENCE HOWARD (39) sits on his porch with an acoustic guitar, playing something slow and sad. Marc-Anthony sits on the step below him. The Los Angeles sky is orange and smoky.

TERRENCE
You came all the way up here to tell me something I already know.

MARC-ANTHONY
I came up here to tell you I tried.

TERRENCE
I know you tried. Kevin called. Lenora called. Favreau called and cried a little, which was sweet.

(he stops playing)
Marc. They're cutting my deal by more than half. The world is on fire. Banks are falling. I understand. I'm not angry at you, and I'm not even angry at Kevin. But I'm thirty-nine years old. I got nominated for an Oscar three years ago. If I take this deal, I'm telling every studio in town what I'm worth. And it's less than that.

MARC-ANTHONY
Rhodey always comes to get you. You said that.

TERRENCE
(a sad, gentle smile)
Rhodey always comes. But Terrence has to eat, baby.

Marc-Anthony looks away. His eyes are wet. Terrence puts a hand on his shoulder.

TERRENCE (CONT'D)
Listen to me. Whoever they bring in, you treat him like you treated me. You call him Colonel. You make him feel like the first one in. You hear me?

MARC-ANTHONY
Yes, sir.

TERRENCE
And one day, when you're the biggest movie star in the world, and you will be, you remember this porch. You remember what it feels like when the money decides things instead of the people.

MARC-ANTHONY
(quietly)
I'll remember.

Terrence starts playing again. A blues progression. Marc-Anthony stays on the step and listens until the sun goes down.

CUT TO:

VARIETY - TUESDAY, OCTOBER 14, 2008

CHEADLE IN, HOWARD OUT AS 'IRON MAN 2' RHODEY

Oscar nominee Don Cheadle steps into the role of Col. James Rhodes after talks with Terrence Howard broke down amid budget cuts tied to the financial crisis. Sources say Marc-Anthony Bullock personally called Cheadle to welcome him "to the Air Force."

VARIETY - THURSDAY, OCTOBER 16, 2008

MARVEL MOVES 'THOR' TO MAY 2011, 'CAPTAIN AMERICA' TO JULY 2011

Studio cites "a deliberate pace" amid credit market turmoil; insiders say the shift gives Branagh's Asgard time to be built practically on location. "IRON MAN 2" holds its May 7, 2010 date.

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "THOR DELAYED TO 2011 + TERRENCE OUT, CHEADLE IN" (Page 1 of 144)

WarMachineRox (Oct 16, 9:02 AM)
Losing Terrence hurts. But Don Cheadle is an incredible actor. And Marc-Anthony calling him personally? Class act.

ShellHead1963 (Oct 16, 9:10 AM)
The whole economy's collapsing and Marvel's still building Asgard out of stone instead of pixels. Delay me all you want. Do it right.

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Oct 16, 9:14 AM)
still no word on who's playing her. the casting rumors are insane. every actress in hollywood is being named

NoNerfsPlz (Oct 16, 9:18 AM)
They'll find her. And when they do, we'll all say "oh. obviously."

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - DESMOND'S STUDY - VIEW PARK - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, OCTOBER 17, 2008 - 11:10 P.M. PDT

The study is dark except for a desk lamp. DESMOND (51) sits with a stack of brokerage statements, a calculator and a glass of scotch. CELESTE (48) stands in the doorway in her robe.

CELESTE
How bad?

DESMOND
(not looking up)
The Lehman bonds are worthless. The Crenshaw properties are worth half what we paid. Two of our biggest clients left Smilley Management this month. One of them went to Donohue.

CELESTE
(a sharp breath)
And Julian's house?

DESMOND
Underwater. He owes more on it than it's worth.

Celeste crosses the room and sits on the arm of his chair. For a moment, they're just two frightened people.

CELESTE
What do we do?

Desmond picks up a single sheet of paper: a royalty statement. "HALLELUJAH HOLIDAY (DEC. 2008 RELEASE) - ESTHER SMILLEY - ADVANCE AND BACK END." Beneath it, a five-year contract renewal draft from Smilley Management Group. Esther's name in bold.

DESMOND
Esther is the only one still earning. Her family movies are recession-proof. Parents need something safe to take their kids to.

(beat)
We need Esther's money, Celeste. We need her under contract through 2014. And we need her to keep doing exactly what she's been doing.

Outside the door, unseen in the dark hallway, Esther stands frozen with a glass of water in her hand. She has heard every word.

She backs away silently. In her bedroom, she sits on the edge of her bed, takes out her RAZR, and types a message. She stares at it. Then she deletes it unsent.

She types another one.

TEXT MESSAGE - ESTHER TO "MAYOR" (SENT)

FRI 10/17/08 11:22 PM

do u ever feel like u belong to someone else

TEXT MESSAGE - "MAYOR" TO ESTHER

FRI 10/17/08 11:23 PM

used to. every day until i was 24. then one day i decided i only belonged to me. are u ok?

TEXT MESSAGE - ESTHER TO "MAYOR"

FRI 10/17/08 11:25 PM

not yet. but i think i will be

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - FAMILY ROOM - VIEW PARK - NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 4, 2008 - 7:58 P.M. PST - ELECTION NIGHT

The entire family is gathered around the TV. Leftover birthday cake on the coffee table: "HAPPY 75TH, DADDY CORNELIUS" from yesterday. CORNELIUS SMILLEY (75) sits in his armchair in a suit and tie, dressed as if for church. HATTIE (73) holds his hand. Desmond (51), Celeste, Julian (31), Simone (29) and Esther (26) fill the couches.

On CNN, the West Coast polls are about to close.

CNN ANCHOR (V.O.)
...the polls on the West Coast close at the top of the hour. In just a few seconds...

A clock counts down on screen. The room holds its breath.

CNN ANCHOR (V.O.) (CONT'D)
CNN can now project that Barack Obama, the senator from Illinois, will be the forty-fourth President of the United States.

The room EXPLODES. Celeste screams. Simone jumps on the couch. Julian hugs Esther. Even Desmond is on his feet, his hands over his face.

Cornelius doesn't move. He sits perfectly still, tears running down his face, holding Hattie's hand so tightly his knuckles are white.

CORNELIUS
(barely a whisper)
I marched. I raised the money. In Montgomery. With my own hands. They followed me home from the theater. The FBI. For years.

(beat)
And I lived to see it.

Hattie kisses his hand. The family gathers around him. Then, slowly, as the celebration goes on, Cornelius stands and walks out of the room, leaning on his cane. Esther notices. She quietly follows.

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Cornelius stands at the hall telephone, an old rotary phone on a small table. He picks up the receiver with a trembling hand and dials from memory. One digit at a time, slowly. Esther watches from the doorway, hidden.

The line connects. It rings once.

Cornelius closes his eyes. And hangs up.

He stands there with his hand on the receiver, breathing hard. Esther steps out of the shadow.

ESTHER
(softly)
Granddaddy? Who were you calling?

Cornelius looks at his granddaughter for a long moment. His face is old, wet and full of something she doesn't understand yet.

CORNELIUS
An old friend. The only person alive who would understand what tonight means to me.

ESTHER
Why did you hang up?

CORNELIUS
(a broken, sad smile)
Because I'm a proud old fool, baby girl. Don't you ever be like me.

He pats her cheek and shuffles back toward the noise of the family room. Esther looks at the old rotary phone.

CUT TO:

INT. DONOHUE ESTATE - VICTOR'S STUDY - BEL AIR - SAME TIME

SUPER: TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 4, 2008 - 8:04 P.M. PST

VICTOR (72) and JOAN (70) sit side by side on a leather couch, watching the same broadcast. Victor is crying openly. Joan holds his hand.

On the side table, the private landline rings once. Then stops.

Victor looks at the phone. He leans over and reads the caller ID display. Five letters. He freezes.

"SMILLEY C."

Joan sees it too. She looks at her husband. He's staring at the name, his hand halfway to the phone.

JOAN
(very gently)
Call him back, Victor.

A long, long silence. On TV, a crowd of hundreds of thousands in Chicago's Grant Park is weeping and cheering. Victor's hand hovers over the phone.

VICTOR
(finally, hoarse)
...He hung up, Joan. He hung up.

He pulls his hand back. Joan closes her eyes. She knows forty-two years of the same silence. She also knows what's in a safe-deposit box downtown.

CUT TO:

EXT. GRANT PARK - CHICAGO - NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 4, 2008 - 11:10 P.M. CST

A sea of 240,000 people. American flags. Tears. Strangers hugging. In the middle of it, unrecognized in a knit cap and scarf, Marc-Anthony (26) stands with Amond (26), Tayia (26) and Harmony Divine (26), whom Amond invited along "as friends." Harmony has said "as friends" four times since the airport.

On the giant screens, President-elect Obama's victory speech echoes across the park.

AMOND
(wiping his eyes)
My grandmother picked cotton in Mississippi. And I'm standing in Grant Park.

Harmony puts a hand on his shoulder. Tayia is crying openly. Marc-Anthony takes out his phone, his hands cold.

TEXT MESSAGE - MARC TO "PASTOR WILLIAMS"

TUE 11/4/08 11:14 PM CST

im in grant park. 240000 people crying. i wish u were here

TEXT MESSAGE - "PASTOR WILLIAMS" TO MARC

TUE 11/4/08 9:16 PM PST

my granddad called someone tonight and hung up before they answered. he said "dont ever be like me." i think im done being afraid marc

Marc-Anthony reads it twice. He looks up at the night sky over Chicago, at the history happening all around him.

TEXT MESSAGE - MARC TO "PASTOR WILLIAMS"

TUE 11/4/08 11:18 PM CST

then whatever u decide, im here. always

He puts the phone back in his pocket. Around him, a quarter of a million people cheer.

FADE OUT.

HEADLINES

THE NEW YORK TIMES - WEDNESDAY, NOVEMBER 5, 2008

OBAMA: RACIAL BARRIER FALLS IN DECISIVE VICTORY

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL - WEDNESDAY, NOVEMBER 5, 2008

Media stocks rebound slightly on election clarity; Donohue Entertainment (DNE) holds steady as the "lifeboat" of the entertainment sector.

VARIETY - MONDAY, NOVEMBER 10, 2008

HOLLYWOOD'S CREDIT CRUNCH: WHO SURVIVES?

Independent financing dries up; Marvel's Bank of America facility is "the envy of the industry," says one financier, thanks to "Iron Man." The 'Thor' casting search continues in secret.

JET MAGAZINE - "PEOPLE ARE TALKING ABOUT" (Issue of Nov. 24, 2008)

Election Night in Black Hollywood

Spotted at Grant Park: Marvel stars Marc-Anthony Bullock and Amond Baker, and Baker's frequent plus-one, Broadway dancer Harmony Divine ("just friends," both insist). Plus: Is View Park's crown jewel, Esther Smilley, finally ready to grow up? Her holiday musical opens next month.

FADE OUT.

END OF CHAPTER SEVEN